

Prefixes

Hyphens are sometimes needed in words with prefixes. Many need to be hyphenated to avoid confusion with words spelled in a similar way. A hyphen is also often added when a prefix ending in a vowel is joined to a root word beginning with a vowel, in order to avoid having two vowels side-by-side. The prefix *self-* is always followed by a hyphen. Finally, a hyphen is needed when adding a prefix to a capitalized word or to a date.

re-formed ← The hyphen indicates that the society formed again. Without a hyphen, the word *reformed* means “changed for the better.”

co-owner ← This hyphen is needed to divide the two *o*’s because *coowner* is hard to read.

self-service ← The prefix *self-* always has a hyphen following it.

pre-Roman ← A hyphen follows a prefix before a capital letter.

post-1500 ← A hyphen follows a prefix before a date.

GLOSSARY

Compound modifier A term used to describe a noun that combines two or more words.

Phrasal verb A verb composed of a verb followed by an adverb or a preposition that act together as a single unit.

Prefix A group of letters attached to the start of a word that can change the original word’s meaning.

Root word A word to which prefixes and suffixes can be added.

Suffix A group of letters attached to the end of a word that can change the original word’s meaning.

Writing numbers

Hyphens are needed when writing out fractions, or numbers from twenty-one (21) to ninety-nine (99).

twenty-four **three-quarters**

**re-formed after twenty-four years
beard- and hair-loss issues.**

Suspended hyphens

Occasionally, a hyphen is found alone at the end of a word. This is called a suspended hyphen, and it occurs when two or more compound modifiers describing one noun and connected by *or*, *and*, or *to* use the same word. To avoid repetition, the first instance of the word is omitted and replaced with a hyphen.

beard- and hair-loss issues

This suspended hyphen followed by *and* indicates that there were both beard-loss and hair-loss issues.

Compound modifiers

When two or more words are used together to modify another word, a hyphen is often needed to show that these modifying words are acting as a single unit. These compound modifiers are almost always hyphenated when they precede the noun, but not when they follow the noun, unless a hyphen is needed for clarity.

hair-loss issues ← noun

A compound modifier before the noun is hyphenated.

A compound modifier after the noun is not hyphenated.

issues of hair loss